

The Mediterranean



IN SOUTHERN EUROPE and around the shores of the Mediterranean Sea, the climate is warmer and drier than it is farther north. People have cleared most of the forests that originally grew here, leaving small evergreen trees, thorny shrubs, heathers, and scented herbs in their place. During the long, hot summers, the air is alive with buzzing insects, which provide a rich food supply for warblers, bee-eaters, rollers, and other insect-eating birds. Large numbers of birds, such as storks, buzzards, and eagles, pass through the Mediterranean region as they migrate between Europe and Africa. The area also has some important marshland nature reserves, in particular, the Camargue in France and the Coto de Doñana in southern Spain.

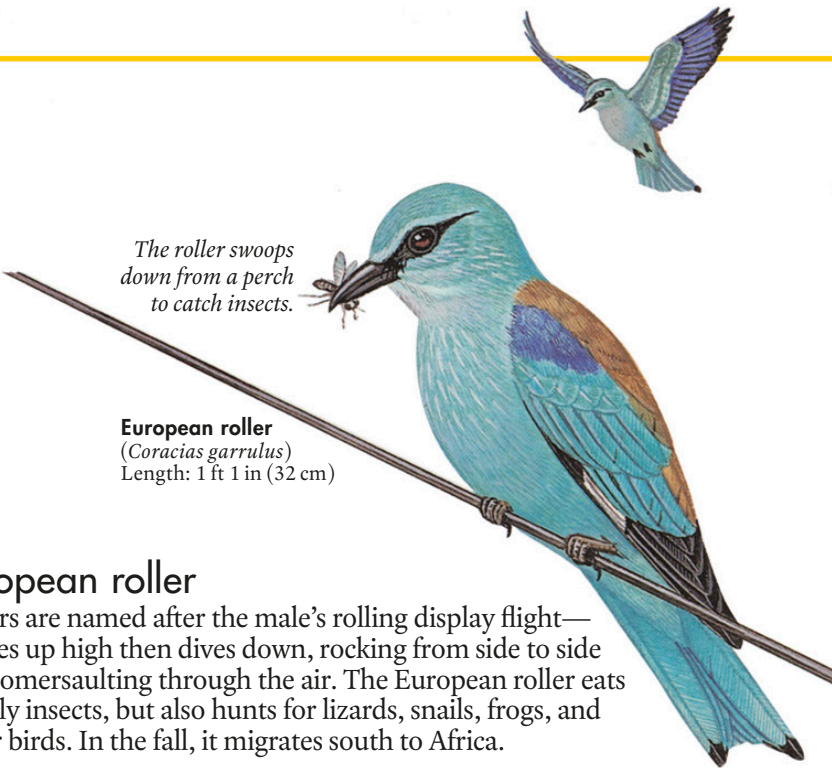
Eurasian golden oriole
(*Oriolus oriolus*)
Length: 10 in (25 cm)

The male is brightly colored to attract the paler female.

Eurasian golden oriole

The woven, grassy nest of the Eurasian golden oriole hangs below a forked branch like a hammock. This shy bird spends most of its time hidden high in the treetops feeding on insects and fruit. The female grasps food in her sharp, stout bill to feed to her young. During courtship the male flies after the female in a high-speed chase.

The female does most of the nest building and takes care of the young.



The roller swoops down from a perch to catch insects.

European roller
(*Coracias garrulus*)
Length: 1 ft 1 in (32 cm)

European roller

Rollers are named after the male's rolling display flight—he flies up high then dives down, rocking from side to side and somersaulting through the air. The European roller eats mainly insects, but also hunts for lizards, snails, frogs, and other birds. In the fall, it migrates south to Africa.

Common hoopoe

The common hoopoe is named after its loud call, which sounds like “hoo-poo-poo.” It walks and runs over the ground, searching for worms and insects with its thin, curved bill. If a bird of prey flies overhead, the adult common hoopoe spreads its wings and tail flat against the ground and points its bill straight up, ready to attack the enemy. When it is excited, it raises the crest on its head.



The common hoopoe flaps its rounded black-and-white wings rather like a butterfly.

Common hoopoe
(*Upupa epops*)
Length: 1 ft 1 in (32 cm)

